



BEFORE

At the outbreak of war, neither side had the facilities or infrastructure to handle large numbers of prisoners.

INFORMAL ARRANGEMENTS

Lincoln opposed **prisoner-of-war exchange agreements**, feeling they lent **legitimacy to the Confederacy**. However, field commanders worked out informal exchanges, based on the **parole-and-exchange** system, to keep the numbers of prisoners at **manageable levels**.

DIX-HILL EXCHANGE CARTEL

In July 1862, both sides agreed to an official exchange system, called the **Dix-Hill Cartel** after the Union and Confederate officers who negotiated it. For prisoners who agreed to **refrain from military service when released**, this system allowed for the **exchange of prisoners of equal rank**. This worked well, and prisoner-of-war camps soon **began to empty**.

COLLAPSE OF THE CARTEL

The system began collapsing once the Union army began **recruiting Black soldiers**. The Confederacy refused to exchange them, instead threatening to treat them as **runaway slaves**. In May 1863, the Federal government **suspended the cartel**. Soon the numbers of prisoners began swelling to **unmanageable levels**.

When captured in battle in 1862, a Civil War soldier on either side might expect some rough handling, sometimes within sound and sight of the fighting, perhaps in a holding area in the rear. If he was lucky, he might quickly be paroled in exchange for an enemy soldier of the same rank or expect to be exchanged in the near future. By 1864, capture meant only one thing: a prison camp. The parole-and-exchange cartel that had existed in the early part of the war collapsed in 1863, and in April 1864, General Grant refused to exchange any more prisoners.

What awaited the captive now would be a fearsome ordeal at best. He might have had an equal, or better, chance of survival had he remained on the battlefield. There were more than 150 prisoner-of-war camps across the United States during the conflict. Every conceivable kind of facility had to be pressed into service. They included existing prisons and jails, converted warehouses, disused barracks, old fortifications, and stockades that were no better than cattle pens. What they all had in common, both in the North and the South, was not a policy of deliberate mistreatment, but rather